EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

# Can We Calculate When Mashiah Will Come?

**Given Monday 30 June 2025** · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 8:3-4

**Sefer:** Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

**Essay/Chapters:** Essay 8 (The Final Redemption), Chapters 3 and 4

**Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 30 June 2025, on Zoom

*These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.*

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## Tonight's Topic: Calculating the End

"We have a very interesting shiur tonight, and that is calculating when Mashiach is going to come."

To the best of the Rabbi's knowledge, **Rav Saadia is the very first of our Hachamim to give a specific date.** There are verses in Daniel that point towards a date, but he is the first to turn them into a precise number, and many followed him.

"Quick spoiler": **all of the predicted dates came and went.** And it is fascinating that the Rishonim who gave dates all chose dates in the near future, and most of them died before their date arrived, "so they never saw it erupting in their faces that it didn't happen as they predicted."

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## Recap: Chapters 1 and 2

The word Mashiach has not yet appeared. It only comes in Chapter 5. So far Saadia has spoken of **ge'ulah**, redemption.

- **Four purposes of the redemption:** to save us from our troubles, to gather us together, to bring us to Israel, and to make us God's treasured nation.
- **Four proofs:** the prophets said it, Hashem Himself promised it, it would be unjust for our suffering to have no end, and the prophets compare the final redemption to leaving Egypt.
- **Encouragement:** Hashem will not forsake us, and if He can measure the waters and the dust, He can redeem us.
- **Two times for the redemption**, from the Gemara in Sanhedrin: the **קץ**, the fixed end time, or earlier, brought about by **teshuvah**.

What is the *ketz*? That is Chapter 3.

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## Chapter 3: The Three Angels in Daniel

**שהוא יתברך הראה לנו בנבואות דניאל שלשה מלאכים, האחד מהם עומד ממעל לחדקל, ושנים האחרים עומדים על שתי השפתות, ושואלים את העומד למעלה מתי תהיה הגאולה**

Saadia's source is the last chapter of Daniel, Chapter 12. (The first verses of that chapter, about those who sleep in the dust awakening, were studied in the previous essay on resurrection.) One angel stands above the river, which Saadia identifies from Chapter 10 as the **Chiddekel**, the Tigris, and two angels stand on either bank. They ask the angel above: when will the redemption be?

## The verses

The Rabbi went through the verses inside before returning to Saadia.

- **Verse 5:** Daniel sees two more angels, one on each bank.
- **Verse 6:** one asks the man clothed in linen, above the waters: **עד מתי קץ הפלאות**, "how long until the end of these wonders?"
- **Verse 7:** the angel above raises his right and left hands to heaven and swears **כי למועד מועדים וחצי**, "for a time, times and a half," and when the shattering of the holy people's power is complete, all this will end.

"Does that make any sense to any of us? No, obviously." Daniel himself did not understand:

- **Verse 8: ואני שמעתי ולא אבין, ואמרה אדני מה אחרית אלה**, "I heard and did not understand. My master, what is the end of these things?"
- **Verse 9: לך דניאל כי סתמים וחתמים הדברים עד עת קץ**, "Go, Daniel, for the words are closed and sealed until the time of the end."
- **Verse 10:** many will be purified and refined, the wicked will not understand, but **the wise will understand**.
- **Verse 11:** from the time the daily offering is removed and the "abomination of desolation" is set up: **1,290 days**.
- **Verse 12: אשרי המחכה ויגיע לימים אלף שלש מאות שלשים וחמשה**, "happy is the one who waits and reaches 1,335 days."

## When is Daniel speaking?

Daniel lives in the Babylonian exile, around the start of the Second Temple. The Second Temple was destroyed in 70 CE and stood 420 years, which takes us back to around 350 BCE. "There are different specific dates. Some say this, some say that." The point is that Daniel is speaking **sometime in the fourth century BCE**.

## Saadia reads the passage

The angel swore, even though nobody asked him to swear. The two other angels heard "a time, times and a half" and **it was enough for them: they understood it.** Daniel did not, and asked. Before giving the answer, the angel first explained **why he had concealed it**:

**סתמתי את הדבר כדי שלא יעמדו עליו הפתאים והכסילים**

The foolish do not long for what the wise long for: the reward of Olam HaBa and eternal life. They only want worldly power and honour. But the wise will persist and understand. Only then did the angel give the number: **1,335**.

## Days means years

Saadia says the "days" are **years**. "This is nothing novel Saadia's telling us here." He brings proofs:

- **A house in a walled city** (Parashat Behar). Normally ancestral land returns at the Yovel. A house in a walled city can be redeemed only within a year, after which it belongs to the buyer permanently. The Torah first says **ימים תהיה גאלתו**, "days shall be its redemption," and the next verse explains: **ואם לא יגאל עד מלאת לו שנה תמימה**. "Days" means a year.
- Prophecies about kingdoms sometimes say years outright: seventy years for Tzor, and **מקץ ארבעים שנה אקבץ את מצרים**, "at the end of forty years I will gather Egypt."
- Sometimes the same verse uses both. Hashem tells Yechezkel: **ואני נתתי לך את שני עונם למספר ימים שלש מאות ותשעים יום**, "I have given you the years of their iniquity as a number of days, 390 days." (The Rabbi noted that the printed text of Saadia here has a mistake: it must read *years*, "otherwise it defeats the whole purpose.") The verse equates years with days.

So the angel's answer is **1,335 years**. "Everyone really accepts that."

## How does "times and a half" make 1,335?

**ואנחנו צריכים להשתדל ולחקור על פירוש מועד מועדים וחצי, עד שיהיו כמו אלף שלש מאות שלשים וחמש שנה**

Daniel understood the link and asked no more. We have to work it out. Saadia is the first to try.

1. **Drop the first word. למועד** just means "at the time of," as in **למועד חדש האביב**. It introduces the time; it is not part of the count.
2. **"Times" means two periods of Jewish sovereignty.** Standing in Daniel's day, at the end of the First Temple exile and before the Second Temple, we had been sovereign twice:

| Period | Years |
|---|---|
| Sovereign in the land with the Mishkan, before the First Temple was built (**תפ"ח**) | 480 |
| The First Temple (**ת"י**) | 410 |
| **Two "times"** | **890** |
| **"And a half"** (**תמ"ה**) | 445 |
| **Total** | **1,335** |

**והכל אלף שלש מאות שלשים וחמש בדיוק, בלי תוספת ומחסור**: exactly 1,335, "without addition or subtraction." "This is remarkable. Incredible."

## The 1,290

Verse 11 gives 1,290. Is it 1,335 or 1,290? Saadia says the 1,290 is counted **from an event at the beginning of the Second Temple**, the "removal of the daily offering," which took place **45 years** after Daniel's prophecy. 45 plus 1,290 is 1,335: the same end point.

## The 2,300

There is a third number, in Daniel Chapter 8: **עד ערב בקר אלפים ושלש מאות ונצדק קדש**, "until 2,300 evenings and mornings, and the holy place will be vindicated." "You see, he's really troubling himself to work it out."

Saadia says it must be **halved**, because "evenings and mornings" counts half-days: **1,150**. Then he says it must be counted from a point **185 years** after Daniel's words, which again arrives at the same end.

So Saadia has three numbers, **1,335, 1,290 and 1,150**, each counted from a different starting point, all arriving at one date. "Obviously he's troubled by that," which is why he devotes the next chapter to showing that Tanach does this elsewhere.

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## Chapter 4: Different Numbers, One End

**ובעבור הדמות הספק בשלשה זמנים בקץ הזה...**

Saadia says Hashem deliberately gave us different numbers for the earlier exiles too, so that we would not think a doubt over the *ketz* means it is untrue. Just as those were reconciled, so can this be. The Rabbi asked the class where else the Torah gives different numbers for the same thing. "The number of years in Egypt?" "Excellent, well done."

### Egypt: 400, 430 and 210

| Number | Where | Saadia's reading |
|---|---|---|
| **400** | The Brit Bein HaBetarim: **כי גר יהיה זרעך בארץ לא להם ועבדום וענו אתם ארבע מאות שנה** | Counted **from the birth of Yitzchak**, "your seed," when Avraham was 100 |
| **430** | Parashat Bo: the dwelling of Bnei Yisrael was 430 years | Includes **30 years of Avraham's own wandering** before Yitzchak was born |
| **210** | The actual time in Egypt | The lifespans of Kehat, Amram and Moshe make 400 years in Egypt impossible |

How does Saadia reach 30 years of wandering? The Torah says explicitly that Avram was 75 when he left Charan: **ואברם בן חמש שנים ושבעים שנה בצאתו מחרן**. He was 100 when Yitzchak was born, so 25 years from Charan. We are not told how long the journey from Ur Kasdim to Charan took, so Saadia assumes 5 years. That makes 30, and 400 plus 30 is 430.

The obvious questions remain: how can Avraham's wanderings be called the dwelling of **Bnei Yisrael**, and how can Ur Kasdim and Charan be called **Egypt**? "These are your questions, not to go into now." The Midrashim deal with them, and the Kabbalah too, where *gilgulim* are involved, "obviously Saadia doesn't take that approach." Either way, one exile, three numbers, three different starting points.

### Babylon: 52 and 70

1. **52 years: כי לפי מלאת לבבל שבעים שנה אפקד אתכם**, "when seventy years are complete for Babylon, I will remember you." That is seventy years of **Babylonian rule**. But the exile only began in the nineteenth year of Nevuchadnetzar (**ובחדש החמישי בעשור לחדש, היא שנת תשע עשרה שנה למלך נבוכדנאצר**), so seventy years of Babylon means **52 years of exile**, ending with Koresh.
2. **70 years: למלאות לחרבות ירושלם שבעים שנה**, seventy years for the **ruins of Yerushalayim**.

The answer: after 52 years Koresh gave permission to build, and they began. Then the work stopped for about 18 years, as Ezra says: **באדין בטלת עבידת בית אלהא די בירושלם... עד שנת תרתין למלכות דריוש**,

until the second year of Daryavesh, which completes the seventy. At 52 the rebuilding began; at 70 came the full redemption.

### Saadia's conclusion

**וכאשר לא הזיק בקץ הראשון שלשה זמנים, ולא הזיק בקץ השני שני זמנים, אף כן לא יזיק בקץ השלישי שיש לו שלשה זמנים**

Three numbers did not undermine the first redemption, and two numbers did not undermine the second, so three numbers do not undermine the third: **1,150, 1,290 and 1,335**. God has graced His people with the wisdom to explain them all.

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## What Date Does Saadia Reach?

Saadia's answer is 1,335 years from Daniel's vision. The commentators place that episode in **371 BCE**, "give or take ten, twenty, thirty years." That takes us to **964 CE**.

Saadia died in **942 CE**. "So Saadia is dying and he's thinking to himself, another 22 years and Mashiach is going to come. Note the closeness here." Mashiach did not come in 964.

### The other Rishonim's dates

| Who | Predicted | Died |
|---|---|---|
| **Rav Saadia Gaon** | 964 | 942 |
| **Ramban** | 1358 | 1270 |
| **Rabbeinu Bachya** of Saragossa | 1403 | 1340 |
| **Abarbanel**, of the Spanish expulsion | 1510 | 1508 |
| **Malbim** (Meir Leibush ben Yechiel Michel), "a standard text when you want to study Tanach" | 1928 | 1879 |

"They've all come, they've all gone, and nothing's happened."

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## The Gemara: Do Not Calculate

**אמר רבי שמואל בר נחמני אמר רבי יונתן: תיפח עצמן של מחשבי קצין, שהיו אומרים כיון שהגיע את הקץ ולא בא, שוב אינו בא. אלא חכה לו, שנאמר אם יתמהמה חכה לו** (Sanhedrin 97b)

"May the bones of those who calculate the end be cursed." Why? Because if you are wrong, people wait for the day, the day comes and nothing happens, and they conclude **he is never coming**. Rather, wait for him.

The Rabbi imagined a younger contemporary of Saadia. "If he believed it was 964, he must have talked about this in his Shabbat sermons. He must have said, Mashiach is coming in 22 years' time, do teshuvah now. I have no proof for it, but it's plausible." Then 964 comes and nothing happens. "What is this all about?"

### The Rambam codifies it

At the end of Hilchot Melachim, Chapter 12, at the very end of the laws of Mashiach:

> **ועל כל פנים, אין סדור הויית הדברים האלו ולא דקדוקיהן עיקר בדת. ולעולם לא יתעסק אדם בדברי ההגדות, ולא יאריך במדרשות האמורים בענינים אלו וכיוצא בהן, ולא ישימם עיקר, שאין מביאין לא לידי יראה ולא לידי אהבה. וכן לא יחשב הקצין. אמרו חכמים: תפח רוחן של מחשבי הקצים. אלא יחכה ויאמין בכלל הדבר**

The order of these events is not important. Do not spend your time on these Midrashim and do not make them central, because they bring neither fear nor love of Hashem. And **do not calculate the end**. Wait, and believe in the matter in general. This matters for next week too, because in Chapter 5 Saadia gives a detailed account of what will happen: two Mashiachs, one who dies, a war. "Something the Rambam doesn't like either."

### Ibn Ezra

The **Ibn Ezra** agrees with the Rambam. On **לך דניאל כי סתמים וחתמים הדברים**, he says: **don't ask any more**. The matter is permanently sealed. "I'm going to give you a bunch of numbers to confuse you, but it's permanently sealed." And indeed the Ibn Ezra made no calculations, because he held it was wrong.

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## How Could the Others Calculate?

So we have Saadia, the Ramban and others on one side, and the Rambam and Ibn Ezra, strongly supported by the Gemara, on the other. Saadia himself does not address the question. Others do:

- **The Ramban:** the Gemara's curse was for the time of the Gemara, the fourth and fifth centuries, when the end was still far off. Now that it is imminent, calculating is permitted. "Clearly, it wasn't right. He was wrong. That's a fact."
- **The Abarbanel:** the curse is on those who calculate **through astrology** and similar means. Calculating from the verses Hashem gave us in Daniel is what those verses are for. "That's a logical answer." But his date did not come either.

### The Rabbi's answer: ripe times

"Perhaps the simplest answer to all of this" is that the Gemara forbids calculating **in a definite way**. Saying "Mashiach will come by this date" is forbidden. But it is fine to say **this is a ripe time** for Mashiach to come: 964, 1358, 1928.

"It could well be that all of these Rishonim are right, by the way. They all have different proofs, different calculations, really complicated stuff." All those dates may have been **ripe for the *ketz***, "but we didn't utilise that ripeness. We didn't use that time."

### And today

"How many times have I heard, as a young child, throughout my years, rabbis get up and say Mashiach's coming?" As a *bachur* in yeshivah, he heard that Rav Kanievsky had said Mashiach was coming that year, because it was a Shemittah year or something. "I used to think to myself, this is it, this is the year." In the last couple of weeks, with Iran, people sent him clips of rabbis and asked whether this was Gog uMagog.

"The answer always is: I don't know, no one knows. It's possible, and it's a ripe time to come. That should be our perspective, that should be our answer."

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## Question: What About the 6,000 Years?

A participant asked about the Gemara that the world exists for 6,000 years. Doesn't that mean Mashiach must come by the year 6000?

"No. The Gemara doesn't say that." The 6,000 years is the grand scheme of things, **the end of the world**, not a date for the redemption. "By the way, this is all assuming we take this Gemara literally. The Rambam doesn't." If the world ends at 6000 and we believe in the Messianic redemption, Mashiach would have to come before then, but when? "A year before, a hundred years before, two hundred years before, who knows?" ("One second before," a participant added.) "Precisely. Who knows?"

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## Summary

1. **Saadia is the first to give a date.** In Daniel 12, the angel's answer "a time, times and a half" is explained as **1,335 years**, since "days" in prophecy can mean years (the walled-city house, Yechezkel's 390).
2. **"Times and a half":** two periods of sovereignty, 480 years with the Mishkan and 410 with the First Temple, make 890; half is 445; together, exactly **1,335**.
3. **1,290 and 1,150** (half of 2,300 evenings and mornings) are counted from later starting points and reach the same end.
4. **Chapter 4:** the Torah gives Egypt 400, 430 and 210 years, and Babylon 52 and 70, each from a different perspective. So too the final redemption.
5. **The dates:** Saadia's comes to about **964 CE**, 22 years after his death; the Ramban's 1358, Rabbeinu Bachya's 1403, the Abarbanel's 1510, the Malbim's 1928. All passed.
6. **The Gemara curses those who calculate the end**; the **Rambam** codifies it and the **Ibn Ezra** agrees. The Ramban (it is now imminent) and the Abarbanel (only astrology is forbidden) justify their calculations.
7. **The Rabbi's view:** these were **ripe times**, not deadlines. No one knows when Mashiach will come.

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## Coming Up

Next week, at the normal time: **Chapters 5 and 6**, where Saadia finally introduces **Mashiach**: what will happen, the wars, and the two types of Mashiach.

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